Are We There Yet?

By Andy Griffiths

ANDY: Dad?
DAD: Yes?
ANDY: Are we there yet?
DAD: No.
ANDY: Now?
DAD: No.
ANDY: Now?
DAD: For goodness sakes! Will you stop it!
ANDY: Alright. Don't get your knickers in a knot.

INTRODUCTION

Parents, everywhere, I get it. You love your children, but getting into a car with them is like a stepping through the gates of hell. Something about a moving vehicle causes them to do and say the most infuriating things, and because you're behind the wheel, you're powerless to stop it.

I remember those long road trips and from a kid standpoint, they really are BORING! But not this one . . . . Are We There Yet? By Andy Griffiths.

ANDY: We've been in the car for two days now. Mum and Dad are at a breaking point. Don't get me wrong. I don't

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want them to get mad at me – it just happens. Like it or not, when you go on a long drive there are times when you just have to stop. And my parents do not like it. But what's the alternative?

Do they want me to starve to death? To wet my pants? To be sick all over the back seat? I think any of these would be a lot more annoying and inconvenient than the few stops it takes to prevent them. I'm actually doing them a favour.

Mum and Dad should save their energy for really annoying things. Like the fly that has been buzzing around in the car for the last half hour. It's driving me mental. I'm going to do us all a big favour. I'm going to get rid of it.

I wind the window down. The fly jumps away. It's hiding, just waiting for me to wind the window back up again. I have to lure it out. I start doing my best fly-call. Bzzzz! Bzzzzzzzz! Bzzzzzzzzzz! Still no fly. Have to do it louder: BZZZZ! BZZZZZZZ! BZZZZZZZZ!

DAD: Andy! I can't concentrate with you making that stupid noise. Do you want us to have an accident? Do you want us all to be killed?

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ANDY: I hate it when Dad asks dumb questions like that. What does he expect me to say? 'Yes, Dad, I want us to have an accident. I want us all to be killed.' But I don't say that. Instead I say: Alright, Dad. Don't get your knickers in a knot.

DAD: *(Exploding)* And stop telling me not to get my knickers in a knot!

ANDY: Okay, Don't get your trousers in a twist. Dad hunches over the steering wheel. His knuckles whiten. Tiny drops of perspiration appear on the back of his neck. He knows he's been outsmarted once again. It must be frustrating for him having a [child] as clever as me. It must be hard knowing he can never win.

The fly lazily cruises in front of my eyes. It's asking for trouble. Well, it's come to the right [place]. I once saw a movie where the door of an aeroplane opened mid-air and everybody was sucked out by the vacuum it created. I don't need a vacuum quite that powerful, but maybe if I open and close the door I'll be able to create on strong enough to suck the fly out. I squeeze the door handle as carefully and slowly as I can so that it doesn't make any noise. I swing it open, then shut. Open, shut. Open, shut

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DAD: *(Screams)* What do you think you're doing?

ANDY: I'm creating a vacuum.. I'm trying to get a fly out of the car.

DAD: *(Shouting)* Shut the door! And keep it shut! I'm warning you.. If you don't behave yourself, I'll stop the car and you can get out and walk. Do you understand?

ANDY: But, Dad

DAD: No buts! Do you understand?

ANDY: Dad's knuckles are really white now. He's gripping the steering wheel so hard that his bones are practically breaking through his skin.

I hear a buzz. It's coming from behind me. The vacuum didn't work. I turn around but I can't see the fly. Hang on – the noise is coming from outside. I undo my seatbelt and kneel up on the seat to get a better view. There's this crazy-looking guy riding an old black Harley. He's go a long red beard, a black bowl-shaped helmet and a pair of old-fashioned plastic riding goggles. They make him look like a fly. And his motorbike sounds like one. Only much louder.

Suddenly the fly shoots across the window. Showdown time! I try to cup it in my left hand and hook it

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out of the window. That's my plan, anyway. But the fly has other ideas. It skates across the window to the far corner. And then back again. I'm chasing the fly back and forth across the window when I notice that the biker is making hand signals. He thinks I'm waving to him! I wave. He waves back. I wave again. We're best friends now.

DAD: Stop waving. Sit down and put your seatbelt back on.

ANDY: But he waved first.

DAD: Sit down!

ANDY: Okay, okay, don't get your knickers in a knot. I give one last wave to Bike-man, but he's pulling into a service station and doesn't see me. I feel like I've lost my best friend.

I notice a movement out of the corner of my eye. I look up. The fly is on the roof. It's taunting me. It buzzes again. I have to get rid of this fly. And quickly. Before it gets rid of me. I reach up and try to cup it with my hand. It jumps to the left. I try again. It jumps to the right and then heads towards the front, daring me to come after it. I unbuckle my seatbelt and dive into the front seat. I catch the fly in mid-air. *(yelling)* HOWZAT!

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I'm lying with my head in Mum's lap and my legs all over the steering wheel. Dad slams the brakes on.

DAD: Get out!

ANDY: But it's not my fault. It was the fly.

DAD: I don't care whose fault it was. Out!

ANDY: Surely he can't be serious. I'm sorry, Dad . . . I was just trying to get the fly out of the car . . . in case it caused an accident.

DAD: You're the only one who is going to cause an accident. Out.

ANDY: Mum? Are you going to let him do this?

MUM: It's for your own good. You've got to learn.

ANDY: I open the door. You'll be sorry when you come back and find my bones being picked clean by vultures.

DAD: Shut the door. You're letting the hot air in.

ANDY: There's no reasoning with him. I get out of the car and shut the door slowly. The wheels of the car spin. I am showered by gravel. I wipe the grit out of my eyes and look for the car. It's gone. They'll be back. Any second. Five minutes tops. Just enough to give me a scare. I start walking. Actually, it's quite nice. Fresh air. Blue sky. Space. No grumpy parents.

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Five minutes pass. Another five minutes. And another five minutes. Where are they? I should just lie down and die – that would teach them. The only trouble is that it could take a while because I'm actually feeling pretty healthy. I hear a droning sound in the distance. Ha! I check my watch. It took them fifteen minutes to give in and come back and get me. That's really going to teach me a lesson I'll never forget. NOT.

But as I listen, I notice the drone has a different quality. Not the putty-putt-putt sound of Dad's car at all. It's Bike-man! I jump up and wave. He waves back and pulls up alongside me. He looks even crazier close up. His beard is full of insects. Some of them are still alive.

BIKE MAN: Well, if it isn't my little mate. What are you doing out here all by yourself?

ANDY: My parents threw me out of the car. They told me I had to walk.

BIKE MAN: Max. *(he shakes Andy's hand)* Hop on then.

ANDY: He hands me a helmet. It's just like the one he's wearing. My stomach drops as he accelerates up the road. I grab him around the waist. Roaring wind. My whole body shaking and vibrating. I'm freezing. I see Mum and Dad's

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car in the distance. *(yelling)* That's them! As we pull closer to the car, I signal Max to blow his horn to let them know I'm here. He blasts. I wave. But they don't stop. If anything they seem to speed up.

Max! Go up next to them. I don't think they realise it's me. I wave. Hey, Stop! No reaction. I wave both h ands. Dad flicks a nervous glance across at me, but he doesn't show any sign of recognition. Instead he hunches over the wheel and pulls away from us at high speed. WOW! I never knew the car could go so fast. Max accepts the challenge. He speeds up. We're back beside them.

MAX: They're not going to stop! You're going to have to board 'em.

ANDY: He's joking. He's got to be. Either that or he's completely insane. He rides right up beside the car and signals for me to stand. I kneel on the seat. I hold on to Max's shoulders and pull myself up. My legs are shaking. Max edges in as close as he dares. My stomach is churning. I don't want to do this. I'm too young to die! I can't do it. Why can't I stay with you? I'll be your apprentice.

MAX: *(laughing)* Highway's no place for a nice kid like you. Go back. Finish school

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ANDY: I'm not nice. I'm really annoying. He has a wild look in his eyes. Maybe staying here is not such a great idea after all. I stand up again. I take a deep breath. I close my eyes. Clench my fists. Goodbye cruel world!

The wind picks me up and sends me hurtling sideways. Thump! I land on the car roof. I made it! Dad s tarts swerving all over the road. He's trying to shake me off. I've got to make him realise it's me. I bang on the roof. Dad swerves harder. If I can just let him see it's me he'll slow down. I push myself down in front of the windscreen. Mum and Dad freak. Eyes wide. Mouths open. The car stops. It's over. Mum and Dad get out. I take off my helmet.

DAD: This is the limit! The absolute limit! What are you trying to do – get yourself killed?

ANDY: More dumb questions. No, I was trying to get back into the car. You threw me out, remember?

DAD: Yes, to teach you a lesson

ANDY: What sort of lesson is that? To abandon me in the middle of nowhere with no food, no drink, no map and no sunscreen.

MUM: We were going to come back.

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ANDY: When? On your way home?

DAD: We were about to come back and get you when the bikie started chasing us. I was trying to lead him as far away from you as possible. Some of these characters can be pretty dangerous, you know.

ANDY: I get into the car. I don't want to hear any more excuses, Dad. You tried to get rid of me. You failed. Let's go. He starts the engine. He's feeling bad now. He should be. We pull out onto the road. [Then] I see the fly. It's sitting right on top of Dad's head.

(quietly) It's all your fault. I've been abandoned Almost missed out on my holiday. Risked my life. It's all your fault – and you're going to pay.

I sit up close behind dad. I hold my hands just above his head, ready to smash the fly. It jumps. The movement distracts me. I clap Dad over both ears instead. Oops! Dad, I'm sorry – it was a mistake. See, I was trying to . . .

DAD: It's okay. You don't have to explain. We all make mistakes.

ANDY: Oh, I get it. Mum and Dad won't try to put me out of the car again. No matter what I do. They've used their biggest threat and it didn't work. It just made them feel

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bad. I can do anything now. Anything I want. This might not turn out to be such a boring trip after all. I just have one question . . . Dad . . . . Are we there yet?

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AWARD HISTORY

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